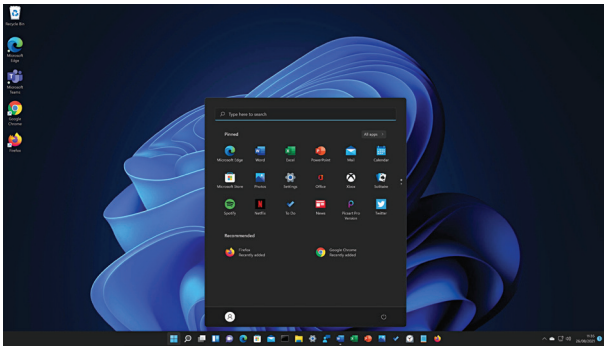




- If Start scrolls with “All apps” integrated, you have the newer Start.

Don't stress if yours looks different from screenshots online. The steps in this chapter still apply – especially the official toggles that control recommendations and recent content.

2) Start menu basics to use

Microsoft's own guidance is simple: Start is for pinned apps, search, and quick access – so your job is to make those three things clean and fast.

Step-by-step: Pin the apps that run your life

1. Open Start.
2. If the app is already visible, right-click it.
3. Select Pin to Start.
4. If you don't see the app:
 - Older Start: click All apps, find it, right-click → Pin to Start.
 - Newer Start: scroll the all-apps list, right-click → Pin to Start.

Fast Track rule: pin for speed, not for *sentiment*. Start isn't a museum of preinstalled icons.

A sensible pin set is: one browser, File Explorer, your core work app (Office or IDE), one communication app, and two utilities (Settings + Snipping Tool).

Step-by-step: Unpin the stuff you never asked for

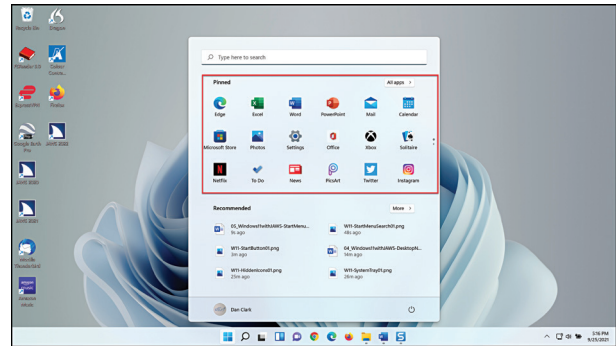
1. Open Start.
2. Right-click any pinned app you don't use.
3. Click Unpin from Start.

3) Organise pinned apps

Start's pinned area is a grid. That's not decoration – it's a layout system. Your goal is muscle memory: your hand should know where “Browser” and “File Explorer” live without thinking.

Practical layout rules:

- Top-left = home base: put your browser there.
- Keep a work cluster together: Office apps or study tools in one block.



- Put communication apps in one block (Teams/WhatsApp/Zoom).
- Keep utilities together: Settings, Snipping Tool, Calculator, Terminal.
- Don't pin duplicates unless you have a reason.

Step-by-step: Rearrange pinned apps

1. Open Start.
2. Click and drag an icon to the position you want.
3. Release when it snaps into place.

Small habit, big payoff: keep the first row sacred. Those are the apps you want in one second.

4) Kill “Recommended” noise

The Recommended area is where Windows surfaces recently opened files, newly installed apps, and “suggestions”. On older Start, even if you turn off everything, the section can still sit there like an empty shelf – wasting space. On the newer redesigned Start, Microsoft has added the ability to hide Recommended entirely (depending on your build/rollout).

Either way, you can significantly reduce the Recommended feed using official toggles.

Step-by-step: Turn off Start recommendations (official toggles)

1. Go to Settings.
2. Open Personalization → Start.
3. Turn off toggles such as:
 - Show recently added apps
 - Show most used apps
 - Show recently opened items in Start / Jump Lists / File Explorer (wording varies by build)
4. If you see a toggle like “Show recommendations for tips, shortcuts, new apps, and more”, turn it off too.

Step-by-step: Remove a specific item from Recommended

1. Open Start.
2. In Recommended, right-click the item.